

Icon of the game: With 151 caps and 94 international goals, Chhetri retired as one of India's greatest ever footballers. R. V. MOORTHY



Chhetri." Another one said, "GOAT of Indian football." A larger banner to its left had bright orange words that read, "Sonar [Golden] Sunil". But the two tifos in the north stand summed up Chhetri perfectly, depicting him carrying Indian football on his back on the global map, just as he had done on the field for over 19 years.

Tendulkar was also a lone ranger of sorts in the early 90s, often single-handedly sparing the Indian cricket team its blushes. So when he played in his final World Cup, the entire cricket team and the nation rallied behind the idea of winning the

HOURS BEFORE CHHETRI'S FINAL GAME IN INDIA COLOURS, SEVERAL PARALLELS COULD BE DRAWN BETWEEN HIS AND SACHIN TENDULKAR'S CAREERS

World Cup for him in 2011. And they got it done at Tendulkar's home ground, the Wankhede Stadium. He was then draped in an India flag and carried on the shoulders of Virat

Kohli and Yusuf Pathan.

"He [Tendulkar] has carried the burden of the nation for 21 years. It is time we carried him on our shoulders," said a young Kohli. Two